Which Side Are You On?

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/52956256.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Elberon Mayor (She-Ra), Ripped Older Woman (She-Ra), Original Characters

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by Kurt_Angles_Tailbone

Summary

As the war continues to swing in the Horde's favour, Elberon has come under military occupation by the Horde. The Mayor of Elberon struggles to navigate the Horde's ruthless bureaucracy and the rashness of her rebellion-minded citizens.

Takes place during chapters 47-53 of They'll Know My Name.

Notes

This is a brief story set in the same universe as my canon-divergent story They'll Know My Name, roughly taking place during chapters 47 to 53. It is also a direct sequel to This Is Where I Belong, so I suggest reading that first.

Row: The ripped older woman as seen in the show, generally never far from the Mayor's side.

Khava Former Magicat soldier of the Rebellion who joined the Horde after relentless racism from her fellow rebel squad members, as seen in This Is Where I Belong.

See the end of the work for more notes

Elberon, at the Horde garrison…

The Mayor of Elberon stared at the document in her hands, breath caught in her throat. The Horde official in front of her stared her down remorselessly, fingers tented, and the Mayor knew she had to say something.

"This…" She trailed off, swallowed, and tried again. "This is too much."

"The quota must be fulfilled by tomorrow evening," the Warrant Officer said, as if he was presenting her with a a solution.

"But… why?"

"An unknown sickness originating from the north-west of the Whispering Woods has delivered scores of active-duty men and women to the sickbay. The 32nd Mountain Infantry Brigade lies crippled." The official tapped one of the other documents arranged on the desk. "Elberon is in possession of the largest quantity of medicine this side of the continent. Thus, Elberon has been elected to contribute."

The Mayor took a deep breath. She had to get through to him for the sake of her people, and they rarely responded well to *emotion*. "Your Honour, we stockpile medicine here because Elberon is the designated distribution centre for miles and miles around. Six other towns rely on this supply—it is meant to last us the rest of the year! Surely the briefings you've been assigned document this?"

The official was silent for a moment, briskly rifling through dossiers. After what felt like a long age, he sighed and shook his head. "I'm afraid your information is out of date. Elberon is *not* marked as a medical supply centre."

"Your Honour, perhaps there is a mistake in your documentation. I assure you, we are—"

"It is ridiculous to suggest a discrepancy in our briefings *weeks* after the reports were finalised," the official cut in. "Why was this apparent issue not raised immediately following the occupation?"

"Your Honour," the Mayor tried placatingly, "forgive me for suggesting there was a mistake. But I am telling you *now*, we simply cannot spare these quantities. With winter on the horizon, people will… die."

The official shook his head. "It is beyond my authority to relieve Elberon of its municipal taxes, mayor. I suggest writing a missive to Force Captain Grizzlor if it is truly a problem. Otherwise, you will see to it the quota is satisfied on time. That will be all."

The finality of it sent a chill up the Mayor's spine. Just like that, there was nothing more to be done. She realised she was still sitting at the man's desk, stunned, when he cleared his throat and gestured without looking. "There's the door. Good day, Madam Mayor."

The Mayor gathered her petticoats and rose, bowing her head and exiting the room. Row was waiting outside, falling in beside the Mayor as they exited the compound of the Horde garrison.

"And? Good news? Bad?"

The Mayor sighed meaningfully. Row's huge shoulders slumped with disappointment. "How bad?"

"We have to surrender half of our medical supplies to the Horde by tomorrow."

"What!?" Row flared, her orange wings briefly extending behind her. "We can't spare that! We can't, right? What about Elwyn? And Prumor? They rely on our deliveries to supply their healers!"

"We'll have to ration," The Mayor reasoned, half to herself as they walked the streets of Elberon. "Trade for extra blankets in anticipation of the winter… cautious today, here tomorrow."

"But there must be something we can *do*! Have you told them the other towns rely on us?"

"The Warrant Officer informed me I can write a letter to Force Captain Grizzlor, but it'll never reach him before the week's end, if he'd even deign to respond."

"This is *thievery*! What are we going to do now?"

"There is nothing to do, Row." The Mayor turned, laying her hand on the big woman's elbow. "We don't have a choice. All we can do is pray to the First Ones this war is over soon."

Row sagged, and the Mayor could see the frustrated dejection in her eyes. She gave her bicep an affectionate squeeze. "It's best if we break the news slowly. Could you pick out a team to oversee the shipment?"

"Alright, mayor. I can do that."

The Mayor watched Row leave with a frown. Truth be told, she had no idea *how* to break the news slowly. People would be upset either way. Perhaps it would just be better to rip the band-aid off…

"Mayor?"

The familiar voice made the Mayor jump. Turning around, she came face to face with a trio of Magicats, one of them very familiar with her striking black fur and bright yellow eyes.

"Khava!"

Relief filled her chest as she swept the Magicat girl up in a hug, spinning her around once despite her squeaks of protest and settling her back down. One of the Magicats looked a little weary, but the other was clearly amused.

"Khava, you're back, thank the stars! Goodness, we were so worried when we didn't hear back from your squad!" Realisation

dawned, and she started ushering Khava off the streets into one of the alleyways. "But what are you doing here!? Did you forget the Horde controls Elberon? If they see you…"

"Mayor, please, I'm— if you could just let me explain—"

"They'll round you up and ship you away! You two, come here!" she snapped in an authoritative voice, the other two Magicats glancing at one another before gingerly venturing after them into the alleyway.

"Mayor, wait."

Something in Khava's voice made the Mayor stop in her tracks. She released the girl, taking a good look at her. She wasn't wearing her Rebellion uniform anymore, but neither was she wearing any traditional sort of garb native to Brightmoon's territories. Instead, she wore simple jeans and a red-and-white top.

"What happened, Khava?"

"We were given a mission, and failed. Rogier and Lara were captured. The rest is…" Khava swallowed, but she had a steely look in her eyes. "…dead."

"Oh, goodness…"

Khava held up her hand in a bid for silence, her ears flat against her head. Her tail was curled low against her leg, a sign the Mayor recognised as anxiety. "There's more. I… I joined the Horde."

The Mayor was quiet for a moment, processing this.

"Why?"

Khava avoided her gaze, looking down at the ground between them. "They… offered me a place. Among my people." A small gesture to the nearby Magicats. "And it meant I wouldn't be taken

prisoner. Truth be told, mayor, I… I wasn't doing too great as a soldier. I wasn't well liked."

The Magicat was doing exceptionally poorly, and the Mayor could see it, from how her claws were extended and digging into her upper arm to how her tail seemed frozen in place, and how wide her avoidant eyes were.

So the Mayor swept her up in a hug.

Khava easily sank into the embrace. The Mayor could feel the tension seeping out of her. The girl had always been wanting for a shoulder to lean on, and if the Mayor could provide it, she would.

"You're… not upset?" Khava said quietly.

"There is only so much hate we can take in our lives. I'm glad you've found a place to belong."

"But I joined the Horde. I left the Rebellion? Aren't you—"

"Sweetie," the Mayor interrupted gently, pulling back to look Khava in the face. "It doesn't matter if you're with the Horde or Rebellion. As long as you're safe, everything is okay. Are you safe?"

Khava nodded quickly.

The Mayor smiled, releasing Khava but keeping a kindly hand on the Magicat's shoulder. "Good. Then everything is okay. So, who are your friends?"

Khava gestured to both of them in turn. "These are Louis and Nicholas. They're here because…" she erred.

"We're here to babysit Khava," Nicholas, the orange-furred one said with a smirk, while Louis chuckled. "She insisted on immediately coming back here, so Percival assigned us to make sure she doesn't gallivant into a Rebellion encampment and gets herself shot for desertion."

Khava bristled, her fur and tail puffing out. “I can take care of myself!”

“You definitely can,” Louis interceded, “but you’ll have us at your side all the same.”

“Yeah!” Khava looked between her two companions with some agitation still, slightly hunched as if preparing to pounce, before she appeared to regain her composure, and straightened. “… yeah.”

“Sounds like good friends indeed,” the Mayor said. “It is a pleasure to meet you both. I’m the mayor of our little town here, so please, tell me if there’s anything I can do to make your stay more hospitable.”

Louis bowed with all the grace of a nobleman, hands folded behind his back. “We prize your kindness, mayor. At your service.”

“Khava, maybe you could come by the town hall later today? I’d love to catch up, and I imagine Row would like to see you too.”

Khava hesitated, but nodded. “Alright, mayor. I’ll be there.”

“Fantastic! Stay safe, Khava.”

“And you, mayor.”

They parted ways back on the main street. Khava’s fate was a surprising one, but not something the Mayor could afford to dwell on. Not while she still had bad news to deliver and a riot to avoid.

…

Later that day, in Elberon’s town hall…

“We can’t afford that.”

The Mayor nodded diplomatically. “It will be hard, but—”

“We can’t. You know we can’t,” Baldwin hissed. “There are no two ways about it.”

“We have no choice, Baldwin,” the Mayor sighed. Baldwin was one of the main hurdles to cross: young, spirited, a hair’s breadth removed from joining the Rebellion himself had he not an old mother to attend to, and a loudmouth like you wouldn’t believe to boot.

“And if my mother gets sick?” Baldwin retorted, as if he had read the Mayor’s thoughts. “What then? What if there’s a fever in town? What if Elwyn gets the chicken pox again? We’ll run out. You *know* we’ll run out.”

An angry murmur swept through the rest of the crowd. The Mayor held up her hands in a bid to stem the tide. “I promise you we will make do. We will trade…” The crowd’s swell was drowning her voice out as people began to argue and bicker among themselves. “We will trade…”

“EVERYONE, QUIET!” Row’s voice boomed through the town hall, silencing the crowd. Row smiled triumphantly, hands on her sides, and looked at the mayor. “Mayor?”

The Mayor nodded her thanks to Row and began anew. “We will trade for supplies with the rest of the towns. We will work together, so that we can survive the coming winter! I’ll write missives to Force Captain Grizzlor and the Fright Zone. I will petition Plumeria for more food and herbs! Until then, we have no choice but to surrender the medicine.”

“Grizzlor *never* listens to you! I hear he barely even listens to his own commander!”

The Mayor tried to wave Baldwin down. “It is futile if we do not try…”

“There’s other things we can *try*,” Baldwin said fiercely.

"Like what, *fight*?" Row sneered. "The Rebellion has been pushed back all the way to Brightmoon. Did you hear what happened to Mastesia? It's over."

"And you're content to let the monsters that destroyed Mastesia rule over you?!" somebody in the crowd said. The crowd's noise picked up as people shouted back and forth.

"I heard they've already stopped fighting, so why should we even bother?"

"That's not true! Princess Mermista is still fighting in Salineas!"

"Many miles removed from *us*!"

"That's enough talk of rebellion!" The Mayor said quickly. "You wouldn't want the local garrison to hear you."

"Why should we suffer and struggle to survive because of the *Horde's* mistake?" Baldwin went on. "This isn't right! This isn't *justice*!"

"Justice is in short supply these days," the Mayor sighed. "But we'll accomplish nothing by raging and despairing. We will do what we can. That is all we can do."

"We should've done whatever we could have *years* ago," Baldwin said. "Now we're paying the price." And with that, the man left, his wings unfurled behind him in agitation. The Mayor watched him leave with a pensive frown.

"Bearing that in mind, I think… we should turn to brighter ventures, and hope that they will be emblematic of our future. Today is a fortuitous day." The Mayor clasped her hands at her fore. "We have three birthdays, and Miss Pattle has given birth to twins. In addition to that, one of Elberon's own has returned from the war today. Khava. So…"

She paused to clear her throat, and that was likely the sole reason that mutter was audible to her in the quiet of the room.

"…one of those mongrels…"

Some people shifted uneasily as his echo faded, heads turning as the Mayor narrowed her eyes.

"We welcome everyone in Elberon," the Mayor began quietly, eyes narrowing on the noisy man. "Everyone deserves a place to belong, and if we can provide that, we will."

She raised her chin, and Row stepped up imposingly beside her. "But under no circumstance will I tolerate discrimination of any kind. You may find yourself a different community and a different home, if you can't abide by that."

The man didn't even bother to meet the Mayor's stare, dropping his head and mumbling in a subdued manner, "Sorry, mayor."

A silence. Five seconds. Ten.

"Good… now, in the spirit of celebration, rejoicing over life both new and old, over our shared years together and over the people we love returning to us… let's have a party."

…

As evening falls…

Initially, the party was off to a slow start, which came as no surprise. News of Mastesia's fate was a blow to morale that was hard to recover from, only somewhat balmed by the fact that the townspeople turned out to have been spared. The Mayor knew she could expect a few more families to show up in Elberon looking for shelter, and the other neighbouring towns and cities were much the same.

Which made the loss of half their medical supplies all the worse. Frightened by what Mastesia meant for the Horde's new capabilities and glum over the news of the new tax, people sat huddled together over tables nursing alcohol and warm drinks. They did as dispirited smallfolk were like to do, reminiscing over

better times and recounting the woes of the outside world to one another. The roads used to be safer this, this winter will be terrible that.

Then the alcohol started to kick in, more townsfolk arrived, and the band began testing their instruments. Chairs were brought in from the back as kindred companies grew bigger and bigger, and then, like somebody flipped a switch, all the tables were removed from the town hall's centre, the band struck up a melody led by the fiddle, and a throng of dancers flooded into the open space.

They intertwined their elbows, moving in great spirited circles and kicking up their feet in time to the drum, their scattered laughter and cheers almost enough to make the Mayor momentarily forget their woes and clap along to the music, encouraging Row when she was swept up in the circle.

Then the youth of Elberon took to the floor, interlocking arms around each other's shoulders, spinning around and loudly stomping their feet, a break from tradition but no less cheerful for it. They sung simple verses that were nothing more than noises to add to the cacophony, and their parents and village elders called out encouragingly all the while.

The Mayor was content. Her goal of relieving her people of their worries, if only for the night, was achieved, and doubly so for herself. Tonight they were getting through it together, and tomorrow there would be another day.

"…my daddy was a soldier, and I'm a soldier's son…"

The Mayor froze. She recognised that song.

"…he'll be with you fellow soldiers, until the battle's won…"

She scoured the crowd, trying to find the point of origin. The band had already picked up on the shift in mood, and to the Mayor's horror they were adjusting their playing to *fit* that very song.

“Row!” she hissed, pulling Row out of the crowd by the elbow. “Row, we need to stop them!”

“…tell me, which side are you on? Which side are you on?”

“Oh, *shit*,” Row swore. The Mayor *never* heard Row swear. “If the Horde hears that song…”

“…which side are you on, boys? Which side are you on…”

Another look was all it took, and they set to it. Row yanked the fiddle from the musician’s hand with a chastising scowl while the Mayor pushed her way through the crowd. The singing was coming from one of the tables on the other end of the town hall, briefly faltering in volume as a sole voice sung the next verses.

“They say in Elberon country, there are no neutrals there!”

She shoved another woman aside and saw him. Baldwin, apparently rid of his foul mood from earlier that day was stood on the table with several of his mates, clutching tankards and singing hard enough to wake the dead.

“You’ll either be a rebel soul, or a thug for Catra D’riluth!”

“Baldwin! Baldwin, shut up! If the Horde hears you—”

And the crowd around her answered Baldwin’s verse with a resounding chorus, drowning out her pleas.

“Which side are you on? Which side are you on?”

“Tell me!” Baldwin shouted at the crowd, egging them on.

“Which side are you on? Which side are you on?”

The doors to the town hall slammed open, sending in a rush of cold air that extinguished several of the candles and seemed to snuff the song right out. Two squads of Horde soldiers marched in, headed by an aquatic sergeant with a cruel scar across her

mouth. She swept her angry stare across the room, taking stock of all the partygoers. Everybody was silent as the grave, frozen in their positions of revelry.

Then the sergeant gestured at various people in the room. "Him. Him. Her. Him. Take them in."

The soldiers obeyed her without question even as shouts of fear and indignation swept through the crowd, marching up and briskly manhandling the accused into cuffs. Baldwin and two of his companions were among those picked out, one of which tried to make a run for it when the soldiers aimed their guns. The Mayor blanched, certain she was about to see a man die in front of her, but as the shot rang out a bola slammed into the fleeing man, wrapping him up and tripping him to the floor.

"Stop resisting!" one of the soldiers grunted, bashing a squirming woman across her shoulder.

"Get off me!" one of the men yelled.

"Fuck you!" Baldwin spat at the sergeant, receiving a kick and a bloody nose for his trouble.

"Hold on! Wait!"

It wasn't somebody from the crowd that spoke up in their defense, to the Mayor's surprise. There by the doorway, rushing inside with her two kin in tow, came Khava.

"Sergeant, that's enough!"

She came face to face with the sergeant, who snarled in her face.

"Back away, cadet. You're obstructing a lawful arrest. Further interference and I'll throw you into the dungeons alongside them."

Then Nicholas stepped in. "The Horde Code of Military Justice, article seven-five dictates that an unlawful accusation. We are

here on commission of the Royal Advisor *Percival*, and Khava here stands as an extension of us. You will abide."

Royal? the Mayor thought numbly.

The sergeant grimaced up at the much taller Nicholas, and then seemed to relent, judging by the sag of her shoulders and slight nod of deference. Khava stepped past her, gesticulating at the soldiers with authority.

"Gather them up, single file. Bring them to the garrison. Corporal," she singled one of the soldiers out, "make sure to provide them proper bedding and a meal."

And it was over. The sergeant had taken to the change in authority well, now reading off a pocket computer as the quartet of people was wrangled into a line and marched off. "Arrested on charges of inciting rebellious activities, participation of seditious singing, under F.Z. codes 2384 and 2385… to be brought to Fright Zone penitentiary… names? What are their names?"

The response of the prisoners ranged from insults to blubbering pleas of mercy. The sergeant rolled her eyes, turning to sweep the crowd again.

Not a one of them spoke up.

The Mayor cleared her throat. "A-ah, I'm—"

The sergeant's stare snapped to her. "Madam Mayor. We'll need their names and their households informed."

"I'll handle it, sergeant," Khava said.

The sergeant snapped a salute and marched after her soldiers. Khava and the Mayor shared a sigh, though there was no more quelling that despair now bubbling up inside her. People taken to the Fright Zone were rarely ever heard from again. As far as everyone knew, it was a death's sentence.

“Khava… it was just a song.”

“I can’t stop the arrest, mayor, I can only make sure it proceeds without further… uh, incident. I’ll need their names. I’ll come with you to the Warrant Officer afterwards.”

“No, no… that’s alright. I’ll go.” The Mayor knew the Horde liked to do things by the books. Accosting Khava or the sergeant was barking up the wrong tree. “They took in Baldwin, Alin, Loriac and Velouria.”

“Right.” Khava looked down at her boots, folding her arms tight. Her tail was wrapped firmly around her ankle. “I’m sorry this happened. I’ll…”

“That’s alright, Khava.” The Mayor tried for a smile. “It wasn’t your fault.”

“Traitor!” somebody shouted. Bemused, Khava and the Mayor looked back at the room at large. Angry faces stared back, all directed at Khava.

“She joined the Horde?”

“Traitor!”

“Get out of here!”

“That’s enough!” the Mayor raised her voice, and then something was thrown from the crowd. A pastry hit Khava above the eye, splattering jelly all over her fur. Nicholas and Louis drew themselves up in front of her protectively as Khava hissed and wiped herself down.

“Stop that!” the Mayor shouted.

“I suggest we depart,” Nicholas said.

“Posthaste,” Louis agreed, ushering Khava out the door.

“Khava, I’m sorry!” the Mayor called after her. The sea of angry faces had diminished some as the Magicat left, grousing but otherwise milling about harmlessly.

There was nothing she could do here. Baldwin may have brought it upon himself, but she’d be a poor mayor if she didn’t try to do what she could.

With that in mind, she left the town hall, making her way to the local garrison as the sun set over Elberon.

…

Back at the Horde garrison…

“Four counts of inciting rebellious activities, four counts of seditious singing, one count of resisting arrest…” The Warrant Officer put his pocket computer down, tenting his fingers as he stared the Mayor down. “Truth be told, Madam Mayor, this is a mercy. There were more than four voices singing in there. You know this.”

“I know, Your Honour, and I thank you for this kindness, but all I ask is a second chance. We are already paying a tribute which will cripple us—not by any mistake of the Horde!—and the people… they were drunk, and miserable. If you were to give them another chance…”

“Another chance? Another chance to reconcile and stoke the flames of rebellion in a town as peaceful as Elberon? You are not considering the future, Madam Mayor.”

“What will become of them in the Fright Zone?”

“They will be entered into the Fright Zone Penitentiary and processed corresponding to their sentences. Once all kingdoms have capitulated, I assure you any standing sentences will be more malleable, accordingly to Commander Catra’s benevolence.”

“Your Honour, I implore you, assign them community service—house arrest! They’ll have already learned their lesson. I don’t think Velouria was even singing, she was only dancing!”

“Community service? Please. I’d be the laughing stock of Force Captain Grizzlor’s sector.”

The Mayor kept at it. “There is a prison not far from here, in Elwyn. Or… perhaps Dryl’s dungeons could suffice? It is on the way, and—”

“We are done talking about this, Madam Mayor. I bid you good day.”

The air left the Mayor’s body. She sat there frozen in place for the second time that day. The Warrant Officer paused a moment.

“…I may see to Miss Velouria’s release. That is all I can do.”

“…thank you, Your Honour.”

Row didn’t even greet her when she stepped outside. One shared look of commiseration, and they returned to the town hall. Looks like there was more bad news to break this day.

…

Midnight, at the Mayor’s home…

The Mayor adjusted her nightgown and lifted the candle off the nightstand. She was dead tired, which was more and more the case as the war drew on and the troubles just kept stacking up. Maybe she needed to listen to Row, find herself a partner to share some of the load with.

At least the Warrant Officer had conceded Velouria’s release. It was a small consolation, in the aftermath of all this adversity.

She tensed. Was it just her imagination, or did she hear somebody shout outside?—

The whole house shook as an explosion sounded off in the distance, causing the Mayor to drop her candle in fright and duck down by her bed. There were definitely people shouting now, and a bright light outside set the shadows in her room dancing.

And inside, too. The flame of her candle had caught and spread on her carpet. With a yelp of fright, she bundled the thing up and stomped down on it until it emitted nothing but thin tendrils of white smoke.

Peering out of her window, the Mayor saw with alarm that a far larger plume of smoke was coming from the Horde garrison, and many of her townspeople were out and about on the streets. She rushed down the stairs and out of her house, clutching her nightgown tight against the chill of midnight.

"Row!" she yelled as she spied the muscular woman's familiar frame. "What's going on!?"

"I don't know!"

Horde soldiers were standing in formation or running about under the barked orders of their squad corporals and sergeants, keeping the majority of Elberon's citizens a good distance away. To the Mayor's mounting horror, a small group were kept under gunpoint by the walls of the garrison. A large hole had been blown into the side, with the destroyed remains of bots strewn about the rubble.

As well as a dead Horde soldier.

She stared up at the sky, eyes wide as if she had been caught by surprise. A wash of blood covered the side of her face and her left arm was bent nastily out of shape.

She looked so young.

The rest of the Horde soldier's squad was stood over her, their helmets off and their rifles and pistols clutched tight, faces contorted in varying shades of grief, mourning and anger.

“Move back!” The aquatic sergeant from earlier today shouted at some of the villagers, who were crying out in indignation at seeing their family and friends packed up against the building. “Move the fuck back, or you’ll be shot!”

More bots were being deployed from the garrison, setting up defensive lines around the structure and playing automated messages to the townsfolk. *“Move away. Do not interfere. Move away. Do not interfere.”*

“Sergeant!” The Mayor called, pushing through the mob. “Sergeant, what is the meaning of this!”

“Terrorist attack by Rebel sympathisers, now move *back*!”

“Madam Mayor, get your people under control!” The Warrant Officer had appeared, sharing in the Mayor’s state of undress: a shoddily fixed uniform shirt with the collar still undone. “Get them under control, or *we* will!”

“By the First Ones…” It was too much for the Mayor to bear. All her hard work, all her caution, all her earnest efforts at keeping everyone safe… and this was what it had led to?

Khava arrived, closely followed by her two Magicat companions. “They tried to free Baldwin and the rest, mayor. Some fucking harebrained scheme—but it’s bad.” Khava leaned in, muttering quietly in the Mayor’s ears. “The 112th Elite Motorised Infantry Brigade has already been mobilised, I heard it on the radio.”

“By the First Ones… it’s all falling apart,” the Mayor whispered, aghast.

“She’s dead!” one of the mourning soldiers shouted, pushing past his fellows. “Allison is dead! They murdered her, those fucking bastards!”

The rest of his squad came up, one of them putting a hand on his shoulder in a display of camaraderie. The Warrant Officer looked them over. For all the cold disassociation with which he graced the

Mayor in their meetings, now he seemed overtaken with a sympathy the Mayor did not think he possessed.

“Name and rank,” he said, addressing the squad.

“Sir!” the satyr who appeared to be their leader spoke up, fighting down the emotions on his face. “Corporal Derek, sir, supervising Privates Hestel, Anya and Alejandro. I regret to report Private Allison as killed in action, sir.”

“Corporal Derek,” the Warrant Officer echoed. “Have your squad see to Private Allison’s body. Report to the market square in two hours.”

The corporal snapped a firm salute, shot the Mayor an unwavering glare and marched his squad back to the fallen soldier’s corpse.

“Sergeant, the garrison is compromised. Commandeer the town hall and detain these terrorists there.”

The sergeant saluted and started hollering orders at the troops and bots. The Warrant Officer turned to the Mayor.

“Madam Mayor, please see to it that your people are gathered in the market square soon.”

The Mayor did not like the look flashing in the Warrant Officer’s eyes.

“I think we’ll have ourselves a demonstration.”

…

Later that night, on the market square…

Families distraught. Friends outraged. It was well past midnight but the town of Elberon was wide awake as news spread of the attempted breakout at the Horde garrison and the names of the perpetrators who were rounded up came out.

Ten people. Ten of Elberon's citizens were in Horde custody, and were now being marched out of the town hall to the market square in a long line. Lead by Horde soldiers and flanked by bots, they were arrayed on their knees in the middle of the market square, their hands on their head.

The Mayor stood at the forefront of her people, trying at composure. Row was close beside her. On the other side of the crowd, she could see Khava, Nicholas and Louis.

"This is madness!" Row hissed, gripping the Mayor's arm a little too tight.

"Peace, Row. For the love of the First Ones, peace," the Mayor muttered.

The Warrant Officer held a grim disposition as he arrived at the square, flanked by two burly lizardfolk. He marched straight to the centre, and a hush descended over the nightly congregation.

"We, the Horde, have given you peace," the Warrant Officer began matter-of-factly, his voice carrying easily. "The Horde has kept your streets safe at night, and protected you from the dangers of the Whispering Woods. The Horde has made it so that nobody needs to fight anymore. The war is coming to an end, and you will be alive for it."
We do not ask much in return. Communal living. Supplies, to those soldiers fighting for *your* freedom, *your* safety, *your* peace. Cooperation, no more obtrusive than the regency of the princesses. A helping hand, here and there, just as we remain a shoulder to lean on, a rock to brave the tide with."

The Warrant Officer's stare drifted across every citizen in attendance.

"And how have you repaid us?"

Silence, but for the sniffling of one of the prisoners.

“Songs to mock our leader with? Encouraging us to fight one another? Attacks on our garrison?”

He took a deep breath.

“A soldier, dead? A girl, who fought for nothing but a world at peace?”

Corporal Derek and his squad emerged from the crowd, joining the rank-and-file guarding the line of prisoners.

“Perhaps we have been too lenient. Or perhaps these are but parasites, tainting the good name of Elberon with insolence, foolishness and *rebellion*. That ends today. Corporal Derek.”

“Squad, at attention!”

The three privates stepped to, straightening with the click of their heels.

“Bring the first prisoner forward.”

“Mayor, what are they doing?” someone beside her said worriedly.

“Avert your children’s eyes!” The Mayor replied, not taking her own off Baldwin as he was dragged out of the line and tossed to the floor. One of the soldiers loomed over him.

“Arms! Ready!”

The soldier unholstered his blaster.

“Aim!”

He put it to Baldwin’s head.

People gasped, covering their mouths in shock. The Mayor winced. She knew what was happening, what was going to happen. But what was she worth if she didn’t try to do *something*?

She stepped forward, enticing another chorused gasp from the crowd. She didn't stop until she was right in front of the soldier, laying a hand on his elbow. Nobody had stopped her, likely owing to her status, and now the soldier was staring her down in a mix of indignation and surprise.

"Please," she said, her voice thick. "All we ask for is mercy."

Baldwin, to his credit, was very composed, teeth clenched and breathing heavily but never rid of that defiant glare. And then, with the barrel of the gun pressed to his skull, he started to speak.

"Which side… are you on?"

No, he started to *sing*.

"Which side are you on?"

Corporal Derek's face contorted with fury. "Fire!"

The Mayor felt the recoil of the gun tremble up and down her arm. Blood and viscera sprayed across the cobbles of the market square, and a lifeless Baldwin slumped down.

"Next prisoner!"

One of Baldwin's friends was dragged from the line as Baldwin's corpse was hauled away, and took his place. On her own accord, the Mayor found herself shuffling back.

"Ready!"

The man stared after where Baldwin went, and then down to the blood on the ground.

"Aim!"

Then somebody from the line of prisoners started to sing again.

"Which side are you… on? Which side are you on?"

By the tail-end of the chorus, the other prisoners had joined in, even the one with the gun pressed to his head. Horde soldiers looked around in agitation, several of them moving to the line to put their stun batons to use.

"Come all of you good rebels, good news to you I'll tell!"

The Mayor looked around. Was it just her, or had the crowd gotten closer? In any case, now more and more voices were adding themselves to that rebellious symphony, like an angry, powerful choir mounting over the Horde.

"Of how the good Rebellion has come in here to dwell!"

"Which side are you on, boys? Which side are you on!?"

"Fire!" the Corporal roared, barely even heard above the din. Another shot, and the man collapsed with the song on his lips. The crowd chanted with vengeful unity, wielding the words as fiercely as a loaded gun in hand.

Directed by their corporals, some of the soldiers stepped out of formation, jostling and yanking people out of the crowd. But the people of Elberon weren't cowering back as they did when Baldwin had been taken away anymore. They shoved, they kicked, they spat, they yelled, and then the Mayor saw a soldier pulled into the throng, vanishing under a sea of flailing arms. Then someone else tackled a soldier to the ground close by the Mayor, and chaos erupted.

"Defensive formations! Bring those troublemakers to me!" the Warrant Officer snarled, evidently not yet aware of the danger he was in. Bots were smashed apart as they haplessly repeated transmissions of *"Move away. Do not interfere. Move away. Return to your homes."*

"Mayor, you have to get out of here!" Khava was suddenly upon her, trying to guide her away by the shoulders. "This is gonna be a bloodbath!"

Shots rang out as a few soldiers pulled their triggers as they were being overwhelmed. Dead citizens dropped down to the cobbles, but this seemed to only infuriate the churning crowd, who converged on the centre with a great roar.

Somebody bumped harshly into the Mayor, and would have sent her sprawling had Nicholas not caught her while Louis hovered protectively by Khava.

"No… I think you have to get out of here, Khava," the Mayor said quietly, watching another Horde soldier go down under a trio of angry farmers. "They won't distinguish between you and the rest of the garrison."

"I fear Madam Mayor is correct!" Louis said heatedly. "These bots are, unfortunately, programmed not to target anything lacking magic or a gun. Though it will come at a bloody price…" and another woman fell over beside them as a shot burned into her chest, "…the Horde has lost Elberon."

Khava growled, her tail lashing violently. "Fine! Let's… save who we can, and get out of here!"

"There, those Magicats are with them!"

"Traitor!"

"Get away from the Mayor!"

The Magicat trio narrowly slipped away as the rebelling crowd converged around the mayor, many hands pulling her back to safety. The Horde appeared to be in full retreat now, taking fire from weapons the townsfolk recovered from their occupiers and had likely stashed away as contraband. They fled into the woods, their wounded comrades dragged between them. Many of them hadn't been so lucky, caught, trampled and beaten down by the crowd.

A resounding cheer went up as the last glimpses of green and red vanished into the night. The triumphant townsfolk shot their

armaments into the air, hugging one another, freeing the line of surviving captives and gathering up the survivors from the Horde garrison. And then that song returned, like a rousing victory cry.

"They say in Elberon country, there are no neutrals there!"

"You'll either be a rebel soul, or a thug for Catra D'riluth!"

Row came up beside the Mayor. Neither of them were sharing in the revelry. Horde soldiers and Elberon citizens were lying dead on the ground, and this wasn't the last they would see of the Horde. As sure as the moons in the sky, the Horde would return with a vengeance.

"What are we going to do now?" Row whispered.

The Mayor didn't have an answer.

"Which side are you on? Which side are you on?"

The singing filled the night sky.

"Tell me, which side are you on? Which side are you on?"

End Notes

Catra can bring about a hundred reforms, but you can’t reform the horrors of bureaucracy or Grizzlor being a mean bastard.

Shoutout to one of the guest commenters who shared their idea of the Horde army's divisions and brigades, adding a little more depth to the structure.

The song sung during the story is a parody of Which Side Are You On by Pete Seeger.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!